FIRST CUSTOMER

First Customer — 10 Days to Your First Paying Customers — Day 4: Discovery: Validate the Problem with Past Behavior

Study guide · Self-study

10 Days to Your First Paying Customers · Day 4: Discovery: Validate the Problem with Past Behavior

How to Use This Guide

This is Day 4 of 10 Days to Your First Paying Customers. You work through it alone, at your own pace, with a pen and your own prospects in mind. The guide is a working guide, not a textbook. Write your answers before you read the model answers at the end. Say your questions out loud until they sound like you, not like a script. Every exercise happens in your own business, with the kind of customer you actually want to reach.

> **NOTES**
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> Most founders read this guide in one sitting and change nothing. Write answers as you read and you will finish with a set of questions you can use tomorrow.
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> - Keep a page for your own discovery questions and add to it as you go.
> - Do the "What Would You Say?" exercises in writing before you look at the model answers.
> - Choose one real prospect or customer to use for the final task.
> - If a question feels awkward out loud, rewrite it until it does not.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

This unit has one goal: to help you find out whether a problem is real by asking about what your customer has already done, not what they say they might do. Here is what you will take away.

- Knowledge: You will know the five stages of the Discovery Sequence and why past behavior gives better data than hypothetical questions.
- Attitude: You will shift from wanting to hear that your idea is good to wanting to hear what is actually true, even when it is uncomfortable.
- Skill: You will be able to run a short discovery conversation that moves from context to a specific next step without pitching.
- Upskill: You will be able to spot a hypothetical answer in real time and turn it into a question about something the customer already did.

Introduction: Why Most Discovery Conversations Give You Bad Data

You have a target customer and a buying trigger. You have an opener that earns attention. Now you need to find out whether the problem you think you solve is the problem your customer actually has, and whether they care enough to pay for it.

Here is the trap. When you ask people what they want, they are kind. They tell you your idea sounds interesting. They say they would probably use something like that. They mean none of it. This is the core lesson of the Mom Test, the well-known rule that you should ask about the customer's life rather than your idea, because people will lie to be polite about your idea but rarely lie about their own past. Day 1 introduced this rule. Today you use it in full.

The reason is simple psychology. People want to avoid making you feel bad, and they want to look reasonable. So they give you comfortable answers. A hypothetical costs them nothing to say yes to. A memory of what they actually did, and what it cost them, is much harder to dress up.

So your job in discovery is not to collect opinions. It is to collect facts about past behavior: what they did, what they spent, what they tried, what they gave up. A customer who has already spent money or time fighting the problem is telling you something true. A customer who says they would probably pay is telling you something polite.

> **NOTES**
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> If you leave a conversation feeling flattered, you probably learned nothing. Feeling slightly uncomfortable is often a sign you got real data.

The Discovery Sequence

The Discovery Sequence is a MEDJAY adaptation, based on Voss, Taleb and Lieberman et al., and it is a fixed order of five stages: Context, Priority, Meaning, Constraint, Decision process. The order matters because each stage builds on the last. You cannot ask what matters most before you understand the situation, and you cannot ask about constraints before you know what the customer is trying to protect.

Context: understand the customer's situation. What is their business, their week, their household, their workflow? Keep it factual and light. This is the stage where you earn the right to ask harder questions.

Priority: establish what matters most to them. Not what matters most in general, but what is at the top of their list right now, this month.

Meaning: find out why that priority carries weight. What does it cost them when it goes wrong? What have they already tried? This is where past behavior lives, and it is the richest stage.

Constraint: learn what limits their options. Time, budget, approval, skill, or something personal. Constraints are not objections yet. They are simply the shape of the customer's world.

Decision process: understand how a decision like this actually gets made. Who else is involved, what happens first, how long it usually takes.

Why this order works: each stage lowers the customer's guard a little further. Context is safe. Priority is easy. Meaning asks them to recall something real, which takes effort but feels useful to them. Constraint and decision process feel personal, so they only work once trust has built. If you jump to decision process in the first minute, you sound like a form. If you stay in context forever, you learn nothing that helps you sell.

> **NOTES**
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> Climb in order, but do not treat the stages as a rigid script. Return to an earlier stage whenever an answer opens something new.

Ask About the Past, Not the Future

Hypothetical questions produce hypothetical answers. The customer is imagining a version of themselves who is organized, budgeted and ready. That person rarely shows up.

Past-behavior questions produce evidence. Compare these three pairs. "Would you use a tool like this?" becomes "How did you handle this the last time it came up?" "How much would you pay for that?" becomes "What have you spent on this so far, and on what?" "Is this a priority for you?" becomes "What did you do about it in the last three months?"

The psychology behind this is about memory versus imagination. Recalling a real event is effortful and concrete, so answers tend to be accurate. Imagining a future purchase is cheap, so answers tend to be flattering. When a customer tells you they spent money on a workaround last quarter, you have a fact. When they tell you they would probably invest in a solution, you have a courtesy.

One more thing to listen for: the workaround. Customers who have a real problem are usually already doing something about it, badly. They use a spreadsheet, a group chat, a favor from a friend, or a manual ritual that takes two hours every week. A workaround is the strongest signal you will find, because it proves the problem is real and the customer is already paying a price for it.

> **NOTES**
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> When you hear a workaround, slow down and ask what it costs them. That number becomes the value of your offer later.

Worked Example: B2B (SaaS)

Practice example: You have built a simple scheduling tool for small design studios. You talk to the owner of a five-person studio that handles around fifteen projects at a time.

Context: "Walk me through how a project starts at your studio." She describes a flurry of messages and a shared calendar that everyone edits.

Priority: "Of everything in that process, what causes you the most trouble right now?" She says double bookings. Two customers showed up on the same day last month.

Meaning: "What happened when that occurred?" She explains she had to reschedule one customer, gave a small discount, and lost a referral. "How did you fix it afterward?" She added a manual check every Friday that takes her about an hour.

Constraint: "What stops you from changing how the calendar works?" She says everyone is used to it and she does not want to buy software the team will not adopt.

Decision process: "If you did change something, how would that decision get made?" She says she would try it herself for two weeks, then ask the team, and she decides.

Notice what you now have: a real incident, a real cost, a real workaround, a real constraint and a real decision path. None of it came from asking whether she liked your tool.

> **NOTES**
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> The Friday check is the detail to remember. It is the customer's own proof that the problem is expensive.

Worked Example: B2C (Services)

Practice example: You run a home organizing service. You speak with a customer who found you through a local community group.

Context: "Tell me about the space you are thinking about." She describes a spare room that has become a storage dump.

Priority: "What bothers you most about it?" She says she cannot host guests, and her sister is visiting in two months.

Meaning: "Have you tried to sort it before?" She says yes, twice. Each attempt lasted a weekend and ended with bags in the hallway. "What did that cost you?" She mentions a rental bin and two days of her time.

Constraint: "What would make this attempt different?" She says she needs someone to make decisions with her, because she cannot throw things away alone.

Decision process: "How would you decide whether to book something?" She says she would want a clear price and a start date, and she would check with her partner first.

You have not asked whether she would hire you. You asked what she already did. Her two failed attempts and the bin rental tell you more than any opinion could.

> **NOTES**
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> In consumer conversations, past attempts often carry emotion. Let her finish before you respond, and do not rush to reassure her.

Apply It in Your Role

You run your own business, so you decide how discovery fits. Here is how to use today's material across your own selling situations.

For B2B buyers: run the Discovery Sequence over two conversations if you can. Context and priority in the first, meaning, constraint and decision process in the second. Business buyers rarely make decisions alone, so the decision process stage is where you protect yourself from surprises later.

For B2C buyers: compress the sequence into one conversation, but keep the order. Consumer buyers decide faster but talk less freely about money, so ask about time and effort spent before you ask about budget.

For your own records: after each conversation, write the customer's exact words for the problem. Their phrasing will be more persuasive to the next customer than anything you invent.

For your own pipeline: track how many conversations reach the meaning stage. If most stop at context, your questions are too easy or your opener attracted the wrong people.

☐ Pick three real conversations this week and run the full sequence in order.

☐ Write one past-behavior question for each of your five most common customer types.

☐ After each call, note any workaround the customer mentioned and what it costs them.

☐ Check whether you pitched at any point. Write down the moment it happened and why.

> **NOTES**
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> Founders tend to pitch when they feel a pause. Notice the urge, stay quiet, and ask one more question about the past.

What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each situation before you look at the model answers. Keep your wording natural. The principle matters more than the exact words.

- 1. A potential B2B customer says: "That sounds like a useful product. I would probably use it if it were affordable." What is your next question?
- 2. A B2C customer says: "I have been meaning to sort this out for ages." What do you ask to test whether that is true?
- 3. You asked what matters most, and the B2B customer answers with a list of five things. What do you do next?
- 4. A customer says they have no budget for this. What past-behavior question could you ask instead of accepting it?
- 5. You are 20 minutes into a call and have not reached the decision process stage. Your next call starts in 5 minutes. What do you say?

> **NOTES**
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> Write full sentences. If your answer sounds like a survey question, make it warmer.

Key Takeaways

Discovery is a fact-finding conversation, not a pitch with questions attached. The five points below are the ones to carry into your next call.

- Ask about what the customer already did, not what they might do.
- Run the Discovery Sequence in order: Context, Priority, Meaning, Constraint, Decision process.
- A workaround proves the problem is real, because the customer is already paying for it.
- Hypothetical answers feel good and teach you nothing. Treat polite enthusiasm as noise.

- Every discovery conversation should end with a specific decision step, not a vague "let's stay in touch."

Quiz

Choose one answer for each question. Write your answers down before you check the key.

1. What is the main reason to ask about past behavior instead of future intentions?

   A. It makes the conversation shorter

   B. Customers answer memory questions more accurately than imagination questions

   C. It avoids talking about money

   D. It lets you skip the context stage

2. In the Discovery Sequence, which stage comes directly after Priority?

   A. Context

   B. Constraint

   C. Meaning

   D. Decision process

3. A B2B customer tells you they use a spreadsheet updated by hand every week. What does this most likely signal?

   A. They are not a serious buyer

   B. They have a real problem and are already paying a price for it

   C. They will never buy software

   D. They need a discount

4. A customer says: "I would probably pay for that." What should you do?

   A. Treat it as a buying signal and present your offer

   B. Ask what they have spent on this problem so far, and on what

   C. Ask what price they would accept

   D. End the call and follow up by email

5. What is the best way to close a discovery conversation?

   A. Summarize the benefits of your product

   B. Ask whether they are ready to buy

   C. Agree one specific next step, such as a follow-up call with a date

   D. Send a proposal immediately

Upskill Challenge

Before Day 5, run the full Discovery Sequence with three real prospects or customers in your own business, and change one thing: ask only about what they have already done.

Use these lines to plan your work.

Prospect one: ____

Stage reached: ____

Workaround they mentioned: ____

What it costs them: ____

Prospect two: ____

Stage reached: ____

Workaround they mentioned: ____

What it costs them: ____

Prospect three: ____

Stage reached: ____

Workaround they mentioned: ____

What it costs them: ____

Total conversations reaching the Meaning stage: ____

Then write three sentences on which stage felt weakest and what you will change next time. Bring that reflection to Day 5.

☐ Three real conversations completed.

☐ Each conversation recorded with the stage you reached.

☐ Each workaround and its cost written down in the customer's own words.

☐ One specific change planned for your next conversation.

> **NOTES**
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> If a conversation stalls, the most common cause is that you skipped from context straight to a pitch. Return to priority and ask one more question.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you.

- 1. "That is helpful to hear. Can I ask how you handled this the last time it came up, and what that involved?" Why it works: it moves from a hypothetical compliment to a specific past event without challenging the customer.
- 2. "What have you tried so far?" and then "What happened?" Why it works: it turns a vague intention into evidence of real attempts, or reveals that there were none.
- 3. Do not argue with the list. Ask: "If you had to protect just one of those this month, which would it be?" Why it works: it forces a real priority without dismissing anything the customer said.

- 4. "How have you been handling this so far, and what has that cost you in time or money?" Why it works: it tests whether the problem is expensive enough to find money for, rather than debating the stated budget.
- 5. "I want to respect your time, so let me ask one last thing: how would a decision like this normally get made on your side?" Then agree a follow-up date with a specific purpose. Why it works: it reaches the decision stage honestly and closes with a real next step.
- Quiz answers:
- 1. B. Memory questions are concrete and effortful, so answers tend to be accurate.
- 2. C. The order is Context, Priority, Meaning, Constraint, Decision process.
- 3. B. A workaround is evidence of a real, costly problem.
- 4. B. A hypothetical answer should be turned into a question about past spending.
- 5. C. Discovery ends with a specific next step, not a pitch or a vague promise.

> **NOTES**
>
> Notice that every model answer ends with a question or a next step, never with a pitch.

References

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